

6 Simple Side Dishes That Will Save You Money

Need a little something to round out your standard dinner w/s? Not wanting to spend the equivalent of your monthly utility bill to do it? Here are six stylish sides to jazz things up affordably.

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1. Two-tone oven roasted potatoes

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This one requires a sweet potato or two along with your standard white potato. Chunk them each up separately, tossing with olive oil and your herb of choice (parsley works well). Put the sweet potato pieces in the oven first at around 375 degrees. They'll need a bit longer than the white potatoes (about 20 minutes). Then toss the remaining potato wedges in the same casserole dish or baking pan for another 20 to 30 minutes, depending on the size of the pieces you cut. This keeps things super cheap, but adds another color into the mix.

If the two-tone thing is too much work for you, consider going with the straight red potato wedges tossed with olive oil, rosemary, and a bit of sea salt. Keep the skins on for extra color, and you'll still have plenty of style.

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2. Spaghetti squash

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While squash in general is gorgeous and affordable, I find spaghetti squash to be particularly helpful with visual wow factor that involves very little work. Sure, you have to wait for it to bake up. But when it does, you just scrape it out of the skin with a dinner fork and it looks fantastic. No mashing, no julienning, no power-mixing with butter and milk. In fact, if you are trying to cut back on calories, you can skip the butter altogether and just go with a sprinkle of nutmeg. Great with roast chicken and another colorful side veggie.

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3. Skinny beans

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Otherwise known as haricot vert, these are the thinner European-style string beans popular in France. They are super simple to cook. No boiling and straining necessary here; these things cook through in less than five minutes in a frying pan. Hence, my love affair with these little strips of heaven. Even